France: Le Pen is now the basecase

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Eurasia Group now believes Marine Le Pen is the most likely winner of the upcoming presidential election (a 40% probability, up from 35% previously), with profound consequences for French, European, and international politics.
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Centrist former Prime Minister Edouard Philippe remains the likely runner-up to Le Pen in the first round of the election on 18 April, but Eurasia Group now places his odds of winning the second round on 2 May at 35% (down from 40% previously).
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Much could still happen to blunt Le Pen's seemingly unstoppable march to the Elysee Palace, but while her victory is not inevitable, it is for now the most likely outcome.

Domestic and international developments, combined with a volatile national mood, now make Le Pen the basecase. The riots and looting that marred the mostly peaceful protests against high prices and deteriorating schools in a score of French cities on 17 October have destroyed much of the domestic credibility that remained for President Emmanuel Macron and his minority centrist coalition. Edouard Philippe, as the strongest centrist contender to succeed Macron, will also suffer by association. The first poll since the riots, conducted by IFOP for Le Figaro, showed Le Pen rising to 36%-38%, her highest level to date, while Philippe fell three points to 15%.

Philippe was already losing support because of high energy prices caused by the Gulf and Ukraine wars, as well as a month of milder unrest among high school students. Philippe's long-game strategy to win an informal primary of center and center-right candidates in the opinion polls by January may still succeed. But he remains stuck between 17% and 21% in the polls, and his campaign has generated no momentum or popular enthusiasm.

Polls show Philippe as the only candidate who could come close to defeating Le Pen in the second round. That should help Philippe attract tactical anti-Le Pen votes in the crucial final days before round one. But all polls in the last two months have shown Le Pen defeating Philippe by eight points or more in the 2 May runoff.

History is now on Le Pen's side. No presidential candidate in the Fifth Republic (since 1958) has held such a commanding first-round lead in October and lost the election. In the four elections this century, the first-round winner has also won the second round. Le Pen now has at least a 13-point lead in the first round.

Moreover, since the campaign entered its active phase on 1 September, several negative events could have damaged Le Pen, but her poll ratings have remained firm or even increased to about 36% of the first-round vote. She has so far weathered a spat over economic policy with her number two Jordan Bardella; allegations that Bardella expressed antisemitic views as a younger man; and the negative market reaction to her implausible plan to slash the French deficit while cutting taxes, increasing social benefits, and reducing the official retirement age to 62.

Doubts about the claimed reform of Le Pen's once openly racist party may yet come back to haunt her. So may her economic wishful thinking and past association with Vladimir Putin (she rekindled concerns over that association this month when she announced she would end French aid to Ukraine six months after entering the Elysee Palace). For the time being, Le Pen continues to benefit from broad French, and more generally European, rejection of mainstream politics.

The riots will benefit Le Pen and hurt Jean-Luc Melenchon. An opportunistic coalition of far-left extremists and young looters from the poor, multi-racial suburbs of French cities led much of the violence on 17 October. Critics have accused Melenchon, the hard-left candidate, of helping to incite the unrest. That could slow his rise in the opinion polls, which had seemed to make him a credible contender to face Le Pen in round two, where polls suggest he would suffer a 65%-35% defeat.

Even so, the high numbers for Melenchon and his alleged role in encouraging both the lycée unrest and the 17 October riots are another boost for Le Pen. The aging center-right voters that Le Pen needs to win in May once feared her. They now fear Melenchon more.

Two other names should be watched. European Parliament member Raphael Glucksmann has bounced higher in the polls and now matches Philippe and Melenchon at about 17% after crushing rivals in a center-left primary this month organized by the Socialist Party. Past elections suggest that this bounce may be ephemeral.

There has also been something of a poll surge by an unknown in national politics, David Lisnard, the center-right mayor of Cannes, who has launched his own party, New Energy, with plans to scale back the French state. Lisnard is now running neck and neck, albeit at only 7%, with the official center-right candidate Bruno Retailleau. Without the baggage associated with both Macron and Le Pen, Lisnard hopes to produce the kind of surprise Macron achieved ten years ago.

Happy to discuss,

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